

WILLY (WEI-LI) CHEN

Old Botany Rm 5, Michigan State University | East Lansing, MI

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EDUCATION

Michigan State University, East Lansing, MI

August 2022 – Present

Doctor of Philosophy - Economics

- ICER Open Scholarship Fellowship

Fall 2026

- Summer Research Fellowship

Summer 2026

- Peter Schmidt [Outstanding First-Year Student] Award

Summer 2023

The University of Chicago, Chicago, IL

October 2019 – August 2020

Master of Arts in Social Sciences—Economics

- Phoenix Research Award

- Director's Scholarship

The Ohio State University, Columbus, OH

August 2015 – May 2019

Bachelor of Science in Mathematics—Theoretical

Bachelor of Science in Economics—Summa Cum Laude with Research Distinction

TECHNICAL SKILLS AND RESEARCH INTERESTS

- US Sailing Small Boat Sailing Level 1 Instructor
- Data Analytics and Econometrics: Stata, R, Python, PostgreSQL, L^AT_EX
- Languages: Fluent in English, Taiwanese, and Taiwanese Mandarin
- Interests: Economics of Inequality, Labor Economics

SERVICES

- Director of Event Planning, MSU Council of Graduate Students
- Social Chair, Department of Economics

May 2025 - Present

August 2023 - Aug 2024

JOB MARKET PAPER

Discounted Degrees: The Dual Equilibria of Immigrant Over-Education in the U.S. Labor Market

Abstract: High-skilled immigrant workers in the US disproportionately accept occupations below their skill level or acquire additional domestic education to achieve wage parity. This paper evaluates the leading but untested mechanism: employer screening. I extend the canonical signaling model to incorporate an employer-side friction on hiring foreign workers, and show that the friction does not simply lower immigrant wages: it eliminates a large set of optimal equilibrium wage contracts, forcing immigrant workers into occupational mismatch. Using a novel longitudinal panel built from LinkedIn records, I estimate the extent of the displacement and identify the critical education levels. I estimate the size of the friction from the occupational wage gaps between the immigrants and natives at labor market entry. I find that immigrants with a master's or a professional degree are more likely to work lower-education jobs than their native counterparts, while those with a bachelor's degree or a PhD are less likely to do so. The estimated friction terms are persistent throughout an immigrant worker's first decade in the U.S., and they are much larger for immigrants with only foreign credentials. Finally, a structural decomposition reveals that occupational skill requirements are the main determinants of the occupational wage gaps, even after controlling for job mismatch and firm-level demand for foreign labor.

PEER-REVEIWED PAPERS

Elbel, B., Zhou, G. E., Lee, D. C., Chen, W., Day, S. E., Konty, K. J., & Schwartz, A. E. (2022). *Analysis of School-Level Vaccination Rates by Race, Ethnicity, and Geography in New York City*. JAMA network open, 5(9), e2231849-e2231849.

WORKING PAPERS

Chen, Willy and Qiao, Xiao and Zhang, Hanzhe, Over a Century of Economics Research Collaboration (May 21, 2025). Available at SSRN: <https://ssrn.com/abstract=5263564> or <http://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.5263564>

Toossi, Saied and Schwartz, Amy Ellen and Chen, Willy, The Relationship between Entrée Variety and Student Participation in School Lunch (August 01, 2025). Available at SSRN: <https://ssrn.com/abstract=5378789> or <http://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.5378789>

Chen, Willy, (Resubmitted to Social Choice and Welfare) Descriptive Units of Heterogeneity: An Axiomatic Approach to Measuring Heterogeneity (July 23, 2024). Available at SSRN: <https://ssrn.com/abstract=4952556> or <http://dx.doi.org/10.2139/ssrn.4952556>

WORK IN PROGRESS

Understanding Immigrant Occupational Mismatch: The Role of Intra-Household Bargaining and Employer-Sponsored Health Insurance (with Elif Dilden)

Talent Reallocation Amid Silicon Valley Tech Layoffs (with Hannah Bae and Xintong Li)

ACADEMIC EMPLOYMENT

Michigan State University, East Lansing, MI

August 2020 – Present

- ***MSU Sailing Center***

- *Lead Instructor—Small Boat Sailing—Summer '26*

- *Assistant Instructor—Small Boat Sailing—Summer '25*

- ***Economics Course Instructor :***

- EC201—Introduction to Microeconomics—Spartan Early Start Session, Summer '25

- ***Economics Courses Teaching Assistant:***

- EC251H/EC301—Intermediate Microeconomics (Fall '22, '24, '25; Spring '26)

- EC812B—PhD Game Theory (Spring '24, '25, '26)

- ***Economics Graduate Research Assistant:***

- Hanzhe Zhang (Fall '23; Summer '24)

Syracuse University, Syracuse, NY

September 2020 – May 2022

Research Associate, Center for Policy Research

The University of Chicago, Chicago, IL

September 2019 – June 2020

Teaching Assistant, ECON 100/200/201

REFERENCES

Todd Elder (Dissertation Co-Chair) telder@msu.edu

Title: MSU Foundation Professor of Economics, Michigan State University

Hanzhe Zhang (Dissertation Co-Chair) hanzhe@msu.edu

Title: Mark A. Simon Distinguished Associate Professor of Economics, Michigan State University

Stephen Woodbury (Dissertation Committee Member) woodbur2@msu.edu

Title: Professor of Economics, Michigan State University